Portland Public Schools

School Board Retreat – August 19, 2025



PORTLAND Public Schools

Draft 8/28/24 at 2:00 p.m. PDT

Facilitator

Experienced leader and educator with a heart for children and a passion for high-quality education



Dr. Barbara Jenkins

Consultant, CGCS

Chief in Residence, Chiefs for Change

Former Superintendent

Orange County Public Schools, FL

Our Agenda



Unless otherwise noted, photos are courtesy of Portland Public Schools

Purpose & Introduction of Facilitator

Norms

Ice Breaker

TTI Review

Governance

A. Governance Relationship

B. Case Study

C. Best Practices Research

D. State Statutes and Policy

E. School Board Meetings

F. School Board Committees

Communications

A. Superintendent

B. Staff

C. Constituents

D. Media

Additional Protocols

A. Strategic Planning

B. Superintendent Evaluation

C. Board Self-Evaluation

Debrief and Next Steps

Adjourn

Our Norms for Today

- Fully engage
- Listen and seek to understand
- Focus on what's best for our students
- Assume good intentions
- Be both candid and kind
- Self-regulate your "air-time"
- What else?



ICE BREAKER: TWO-THIRDS TRUTH



Share Results from Team Report

Talent Insights® Team Report

Portland Public Schools: Team Report

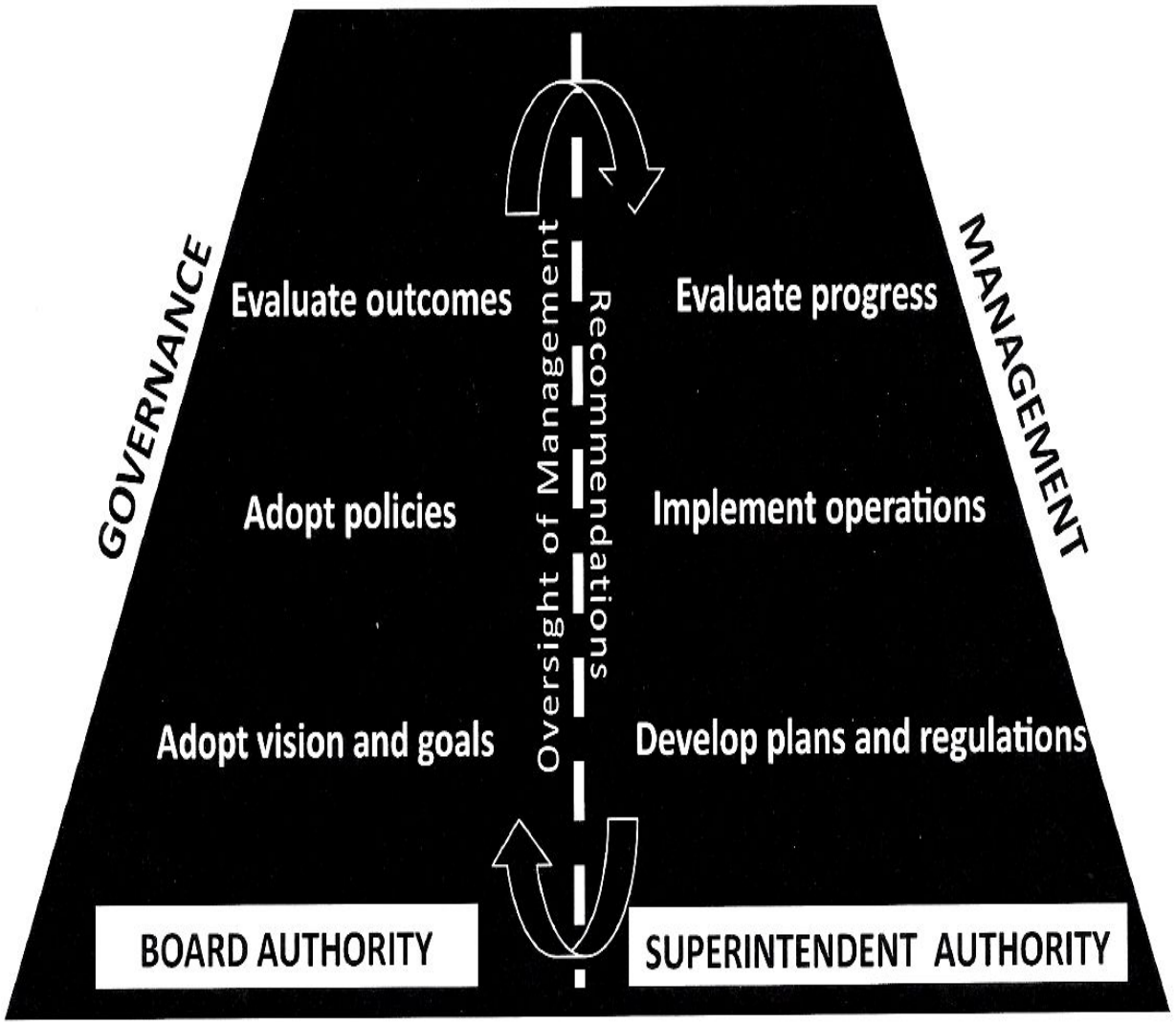
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TTI SUCCESS INSIGHTS®

Photo courtesy Cedar Rapids Community School District

Governance Relationship



Courtesy Florida School Boards Association

Governance Relationship - Simplified

The School Board…

- Sets a vision and goals that reflect community priorities
- Hires and evaluates a superintendent
- Creates policy and adopts a budget
- Monitors progress toward vision and goals



The Superintendent…

- Takes direction on vision and goals from the School Board as a whole
- Implements Board policy and leads the school district toward the Board's visions and goals
- Manages the day-to-day operations of the school district, and hires / supervises personnel
- Makes recommendations on policy and resources, reports on progress toward goals

Governance Relationship

Harvard Business School Case Study

“New Director Dilemmas: Blurring the Line Between Governance and Management”
John J-H Kim, Harvard Business Publishing, 2021.



Photo: Web stock picture

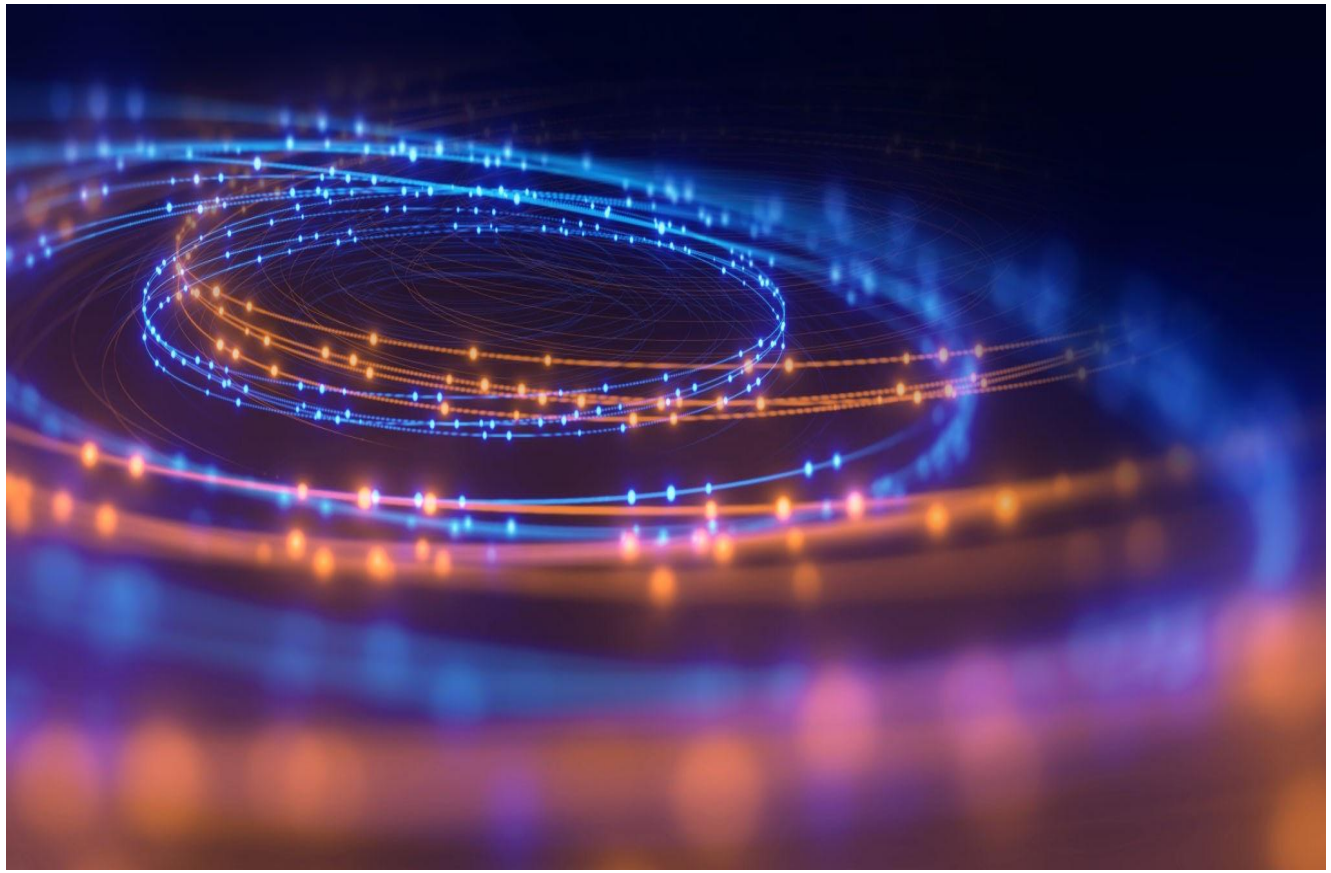
Research on School Board Governance

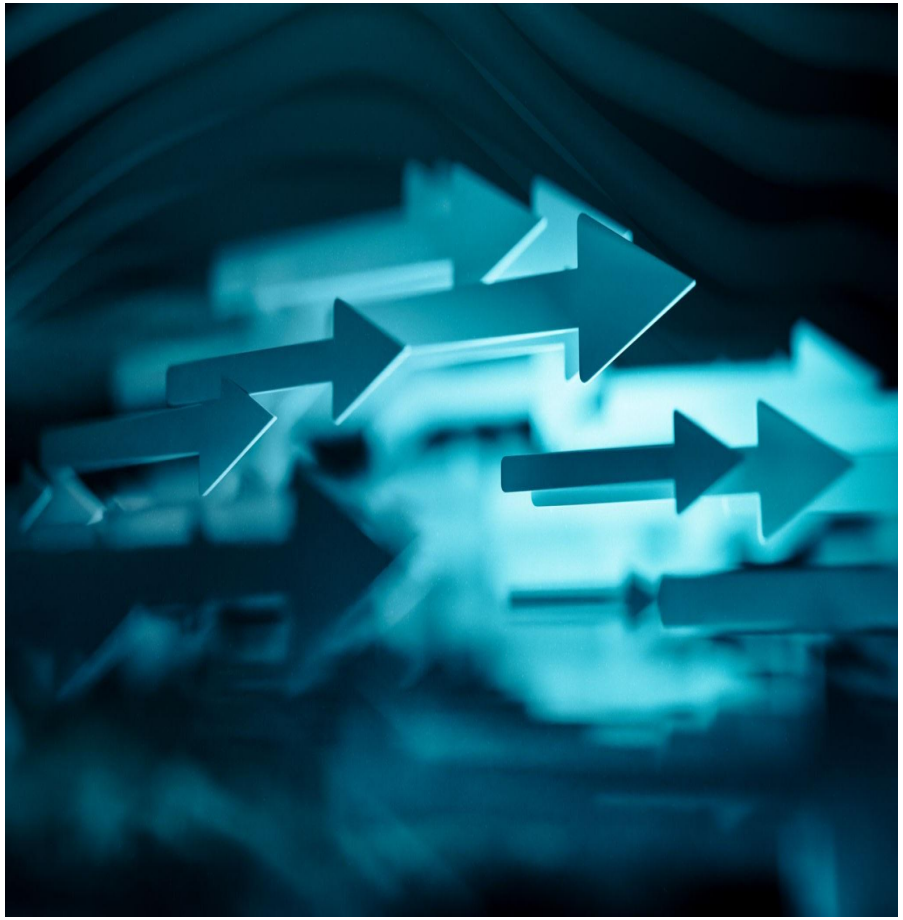


"Our vision is of a governance system, school board and superintendent working together as a cohesive, unified team with a common vision driven by a shared moral imperative. This is a dynamic, powerful role for school boards... it is a governance system that fulfills its responsibility to all the children and the community it serves." - Campbell & Fullan

Source: Campbell, D., & Fullan, M. (2019). *The Governance Core: School boards, Superintendents, and Schools Working Together*. Corwin Press.

COHERENCE CONCEPT





Effective School Boards…

1. Commit to a vision of high expectations for student achievement and quality instruction and define clear goals toward that vision.

2. Have strong shared beliefs and values about what is possible for students and their ability to learn, and of the system and its ability to teach all children at high levels.

3. Are accountability driven, spending less time on operational issues and more time focused on policies to improve student achievement.

4. Have a collaborative relationship with staff and the community and establish a strong communications structure to inform and engage both internal and external stakeholders in setting and achieving district goals.

5. Are data savvy; they embrace and monitor data, even when the information is negative, and use it to drive continuous improvement.

6. Align and sustain resources, such as professional development, to meet district goals.

7. Lead as a united team with the superintendent, each from their respective roles, with strong collaboration and mutual trust.

8. Take part in team development and training, sometimes with their superintendents, to build shared knowledge, values and commitments for their improvement efforts.

Source: Dervarics, C., & O'Brien, E. (2019). *Eight Characteristics of Effective School Boards*. Center for Public Education.
www.nsba.org/-/media/NSBA/File/cpe-eight-characteristics-of-effective-school-boards-report-december-2019.pdf

Effective School Boards: Factors Associated with Student Achievement

1. **Creating a vision** – Effective boards are actively involved with district leaders and the community in creating a clear, long-term, shared vision for the district
2. **Using data** – Utilize data to set goals, establish accountability for themselves and others, monitor progress, apply pressure, and inform decision making
3. **Setting goals** - Collaboratively establish a few reasonable, nonnegotiable goals for student achievement and instruction
4. **Monitoring progress and taking corrective action.**
5. **Creating awareness and urgency** – especially about any gap between the vision and outcome data.
6. **Engaging the community** - in pursuit of the district's shared vision and goals.
7. **Connecting with district leadership** - in pursuit of the district's vision and goals in ways that complement the superintendent's implementation efforts.
8. **Creating climate** - characterized by participatory decision making and a commitment to high-quality teaching and learning.
9. **Providing staff development** – invest in quality professional learning for all staff focused on improving instruction.
10. **Developing policy with a focus on student learning.**
11. **Demonstrating commitment –** to the district's vision and goals by allocating time and resources.
12. **Practicing unified governance** – where the Board and superintendent have complementary roles in policy development and implementation (respectively) that lead toward achieving district vision and goals.

Source: Johnson, P. A. (2023). *Effective board leadership: Factors associated with student achievement*. Journal of School Leadership, 23(5).

More Research

More Research on the Impact of Effective School Boards on Student Learning:

Goodman, R. H., Fulbright, L., & Zimmerman Jr, W. G. (1997). *Getting There from Here. School Board-Superintendent Collaboration: Creating a School Governance Team Capable of Raising Student Achievement.* Educational Research Service.

Snipes, J., Doolittle, F., & Herlihy, C. (2002). *Foundations for Success: Case Studies of How Urban School Systems Improve Student Achievement*, Council of the Great City Schools.

Marzano, R. J., & Waters, T. (2009). *District Leadership That Works: Striking the Right Balance*. Solution Tree Press.



Question for reflection:

Are there policies, structures, mutual commitments, and/or practices that could bring our School Board into closer alignment with the effective school boards research?



Governance Relationship



Oregon Revised Statutes

332.072 Legal status of school districts. All school districts are bodies corporate, and the district school board is authorized to transact all business coming within the jurisdiction of the district and to sue and be sued. Pursuant to law, district school boards have control of the district schools and are responsible for educating children residing in the district.

Governance Relationship – Powers of the Board

332.075 Powers of board; **rules**.

(1) Any district school board may:

(a) **Fix the days of the year and the hours of the day** when schools shall be in session.

(b) Adopt **textbooks and other instructional materials** as provided in ORS 337.120 and 337.141 and courses of study for the use of such schools as provided in ORS 336.035.

* * *

(d) Develop and operate with other school districts or community college districts secondary **career and technical education programs for pupils of more than one district** and fix by agreement the duration of the district's obligation to continue such activity, subject to the availability of funds therefor.

(e) Authorize the school district to be a member of and pay fees, if any, to any voluntary organization that administers **interscholastic activities or that facilitates the scheduling and programming of interscholastic activities** only if the organization:

* * *

(f) **Accept money** or property donated for the use or benefit of the school district and, consistent with the laws of this state, use such money or property for the purpose for which it was donated.

(g) Enter into an approved written agreement with the governing body of a federally recognized Native American tribe in Oregon to allow the use of a **mascot** that represents, is associated with or is significant to the Native American tribe entering into the agreement.

* * *

Governance Relationship – Powers of the Board (cont'd)

332.075 Powers of board; rules.

* * *

(2) **All contracts of the school district must be approved by the district school board before an order can be drawn for payment.** If a contract is made without the authority of the district school board, the individual making such contract shall be personally liable.

(3) Notwithstanding subsection (2) of this section, a district school board **may,** by resolution or policy, **authorize its superintendent** or the superintendent's designee to enter into and approve payment on contracts for products, materials, supplies, capital outlay, equipment and services that are within appropriations made by the district school board pursuant to ORS 294.456. A district school board **may not** authorize its superintendent or the superintendent's designee under this subsection to enter into and approve payment on contracts that are **collective bargaining agreements or service contracts that include the provision of labor performed by employees of the school district**.

Governance Relationship – Duties of the Board

332.105 General duties of board.

(1) The **general duties** of district school boards are:

(a) To cause to be used in the district state blanks, registers and other forms, whenever supplied and required by the state.
(b) To perform such other duties as the wants of the district may from time to time demand.

(2) The district school board may participate in the activities of and may become members of associations of school boards. When provided for in an approved school district budget, the board may pay from school district funds annual dues to such association.

332.107 Rules for school government. Each district school board shall establish **rules for the government** of the schools and pupils consistent with the rules of the State Board of Education.

Governance Relationship

Governing documents on **Board-Superintendent Relationship**:

- Policy 1.10.010-P Role of the Board of Education
- Resolution 6298 Board and Superintendent / Staff Expectations and Operating Protocols (adopted 5/11/21)

Questions:

- Do these guidelines sound appropriate and comprehensive to you?
- Anything missing? Anything need to be adjusted?
- What enables the Board to fully adhere to these structures?



Board Committees



Examining the role of Board Committees.

- What is the purpose of Board Committees?
- How are Board committees helpful in achieving the goals of the Board?
- What is the relationship of the Board and Superintendent to Board Committees?
- How should Board Committees communicate their on-going work and recommendations?
- How should the chair keep the entire board fully informed?

Review current protocols / charters.

Reminder about public meetings and communication.

School Board Meetings



Review current protocols.

- Agenda Setting: Are committee recommendations automatically added to Board meeting agendas? (What are the responsibilities of the Board Chair?)

- Board information and materials: Timeline for providing various documents? Are there exceptions and/or grace in certain circumstances?

- Consent agenda protocols: When can an item be removed? How communicated? Consensus that item is removed from consent, but not from the School Board agenda.

Communication: Superintendent



Review current protocols.

Consider additional points for discussion:

- Superintendent will share information with the Board through a variety of channels:
  - Superintendent Report at Board Meetings
  - Weekly e-mail updates from the Superintendent
  - Additional e-mail updates as needed between meetings
  - Phone calls for more sensitive matters that require a more nuanced conversation
  - Text messages for critical, emergent, and time-sensitive situations
- With the exception of some communication with the Board Chair, all Board members will receive the same relevant information in approximately the same timeframe.
- Answers to a substantive question or information request from an individual Board member be shared with all Board members.
- The Superintendent will seek to deepen personal and professional relationships with each individual board member through periodic 1:1 meetings, and occasional 1:1 lunches and/or school visits.

Communication: District Employees



Review current protocols.

Consider additional points for discussion:

- Board members are encouraged to have appropriate, positive, professional relationships with district employees, including teachers, administrators and other staff.
- Recognizing that the Superintendent supervises all district employees, individual Board members will refrain from giving directives to district employees.
- In the near-term, any Board member requests for information or substantive questions will be sent to the Superintendent (with Senior Board manager copied) for follow-up and response.

Communication: Constituents



Review current protocols.

Consider additional points for discussion:

- Constituent questions or concerns about a particular classroom or school should be referred back into the district at the appropriate level (e.g. teacher, principal, etc.).
- Issues that are unresolved at the school level (or represent larger systemic concerns) should be brought to the attention of the superintendent to be addressed by appropriate staff.
- If an individual board member has concerns about school district personnel, those concerns should be raised directly with the superintendent, and received as important feedback, but not as a directive.

Communication: Media



Photo: Web stock picture

Review current protocols.

Consider additional points for discussion:

- The Board Chair should be the primary spokesperson for the School Board with the media.
- Individual Board members who intend to respond to media inquires are encouraged to utilize the Office of Communications as a resource to assist in managing the interaction.
- Once a vote has been taken and a decision made, all Board members should publicly support the action of the Board as a body, or not comment.
- The Superintendent should serve as the primary spokesperson for the school district with the media.
- Individual Board members should take great care in interacting with the public on social media about issues that affect the school district or may come before the Board. All such interactions should reflect positively on the district and the Board.

Additional Protocols

- Strategic Planning
- Superintendent Evaluation
- Board Self-Evaluation



Where have we been and where are we going?

2019

In partnership with community, Superintendent Guerrero develops the PPS reImagined Vision and Graduate Portrait.



2021

PPS Forward Together Strategic Plan launched for 2020-2025, which prioritizes creation of a new Instructional Framework to provide a consistent, district-wide vision for high-quality teaching and learning.

PPS FORWARD TOGETHER

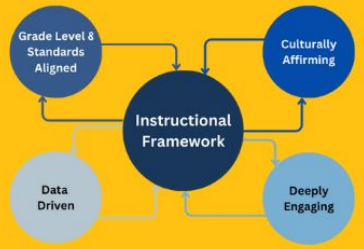
Feb-June 2022

First version of the PPS Instructional Framework is developed by a Design Team of central office instructional leaders with feedback from building leaders, teachers, and community.

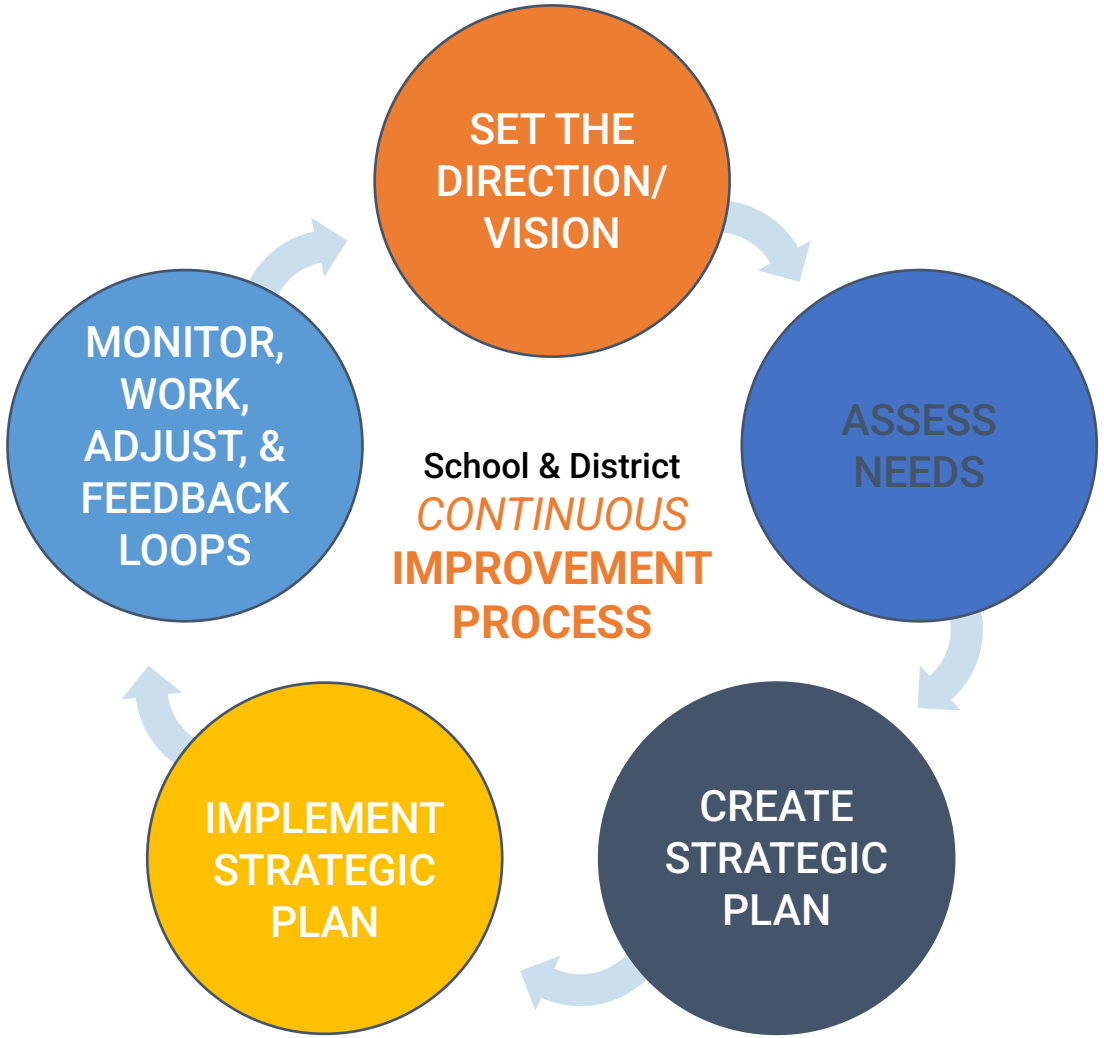


Summer 2022

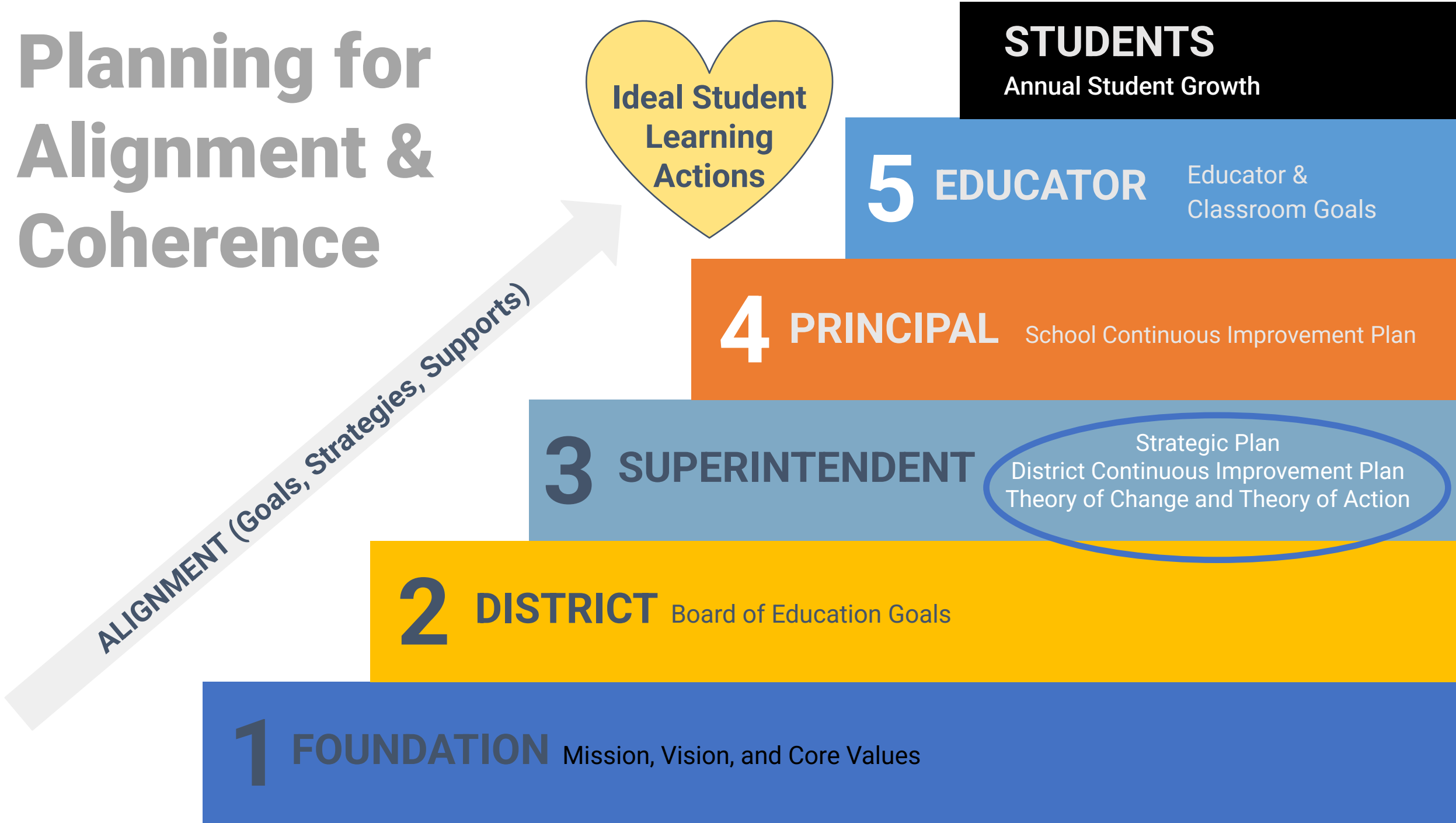
Three year implementation plan (2022-2025) is developed, focusing first on Grade Level Standards Aligned then expanding to Culturally Affirming, Deeply Engaging, and Data Driven.



Setting the Direction/ Vision for Continuous Improvement



Planning for Alignment & Coherence



District Continuous Improvement Plan: Four Goal Areas



ATTENDANCE

LITERACY

MATH

9th Grade SUCCESS

District Continuous Improvement Plan - with alignment School Continuous Improvement Plans

Mission, Vision, Board Goals

Theory of Change, Theory of Action

Additional Framing & Background

Comprehensive Needs Assessment for Equity & Focal Students



ATTENDANCE



LITERACY



MATH



9th Grade SUCCESS

Superintendent Evaluation



Review current protocols.

- Is the instrument adopted via Resolution #6559 on 8/9/22 still the tool the Board wishes to utilize to assess the superintendent's performance?

- What are the qualitative elements of the Board evaluation of Superintendent?
- How "public" should constructive feedback to the Superintendent be?

Superintendent Evaluation



Consider additional points for discussion:

- The Superintendent will be evaluated annually by the School Board.
- The Board, in conversation with the Superintendent, will identify three to five major performance areas aligned to the Board's vision and goals (e.g. student learning outcomes, closing achievement gaps, community engagement, effective use of resources, etc.) upon which to assess the Superintendent.
- The evaluation will highlight student learning data, but will be in the form of a narrative report and discussion with the Superintendent regarding progress in each performance area.
- The Board Chair will solicit a self-evaluation from the superintendent as well as a narrative assessment from each individual board member. The Board Chair (or Board designee) will then synthesize the feedback into an overall narrative evaluation report.
- The overall report will be presented to the Superintendent.

School Board Self-Evaluation



Review current protocols.

Consider additional points for discussion:

- There are several reputable School Board self-evaluation instruments that the Board might consider:
  - Council of the Great City Schools
  - School Board Partners
  - Oregon School Boards Association
  - TNT

- Alternatively, an annual School Board self-evaluation tool could be developed based on the specific needs of the School Board here in Portland.

Wrap Up

- Identification of Next Steps
- Reflections on the day (Pluses & Deltas)
- Thank you!



PORTLAND
Public Schools

